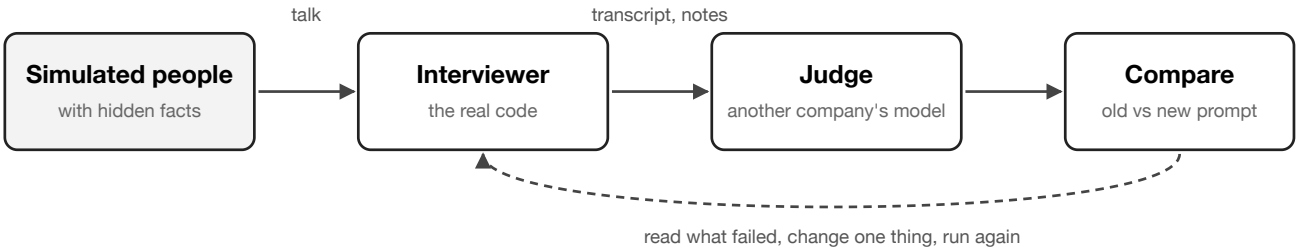
How the Viven interviewer is tested

Utkarsh Kanwat · November 2026 · eval/ in the repo

The question to answer: if a prompt change takes capture from 50% to 70%, how do I know it really did, and that nothing else broke on the way, like people getting annoyed and leaving? Real conversations can't tell you, because nobody knows what the person could have said. So I test against simulated people whose answers I wrote down first.



A loop: run the interviewer on the same people, grade it, compare with the last version, and fix what went wrong.

1 People with an answer key

There are ten simulated people: a retired school principal, a terse engineer, a farmer who takes a while to trust you, a busy founder, and so on. Each has ten to twelve hidden facts. Some they share freely, some only if asked, some only if pushed gently, and some only once they trust the interviewer. Each also has five questions an outsider might ask their twin, with the right answers. They behave like people: they get annoyed by repeated or double questions, they can walk out, and halfway they say "call me later" and come back in a new session. They talk to the same code the website runs, through its API, in text instead of voice.

2 What gets graded

A model from a different company than the interviewer's does the grading. It checks how many hidden facts the person said and how many made it into the notes, counting the important ones double. Then another model answers the outsider questions using only the notes, and the judge marks each answer right, partly right, wrong, or "don't know". It also checks every question the interviewer asked (repeated, two questions in one, pressing after a no, praise) and whether every note is backed by something the person actually said.

3 Did something else break?

A change is judged on one main score, but a list of guard scores must not get worse: people walking out, how annoyed they got, re-asked questions, notes that aren't backed by the transcript, made-up answers. Both versions run on the same people with the same seeds, and the result comes with a range, so small differences aren't mistaken for progress. In one real round, a change that made it move on sooner covered more of each person's life (2.8 areas instead of 2.0) and drew out slightly more facts, but the guards showed re-asked questions going up and one person getting worse. I kept the change and the problem stayed on the list.

4 Checking the checker

A judge can be wrong too. The same conversations are graded twice to see how often its labels flip, the same people are run on two seeds to see how big a change has to be before it shows, and a review page lets me mark conversations myself and compare my marks with the judge's. Half the people are held back: prompt changes come from failures on the first five, and only count if they also help the other five.

Real conversations

Real people have no answer key. For them, the judge writes the questions people would likely ask their twin, answers them from the notes, and checks each answer against everything they said. New conversations from the website are pulled in every two hours for review. Still to do: the held-back people haven't been run yet because the credit ran out, and my own marks for checking the judge aren't done.

Run with node eval/run.ts (sim, grade, compare, view, meta). Grading is cached, so regrading old runs costs nothing. Every round is written up in THINKING.md.